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Managing Motherhood: How Incarcerated Mothers Negotiate Maternal Role-Identities with Their Children's Caregivers

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ABSTRACT

Women's incarceration rates have increased dramatically within the last 40 years. Many of the women who find themselves in the grips of confinement are mothers. Maternity can be central to women's identities, making them reluctant to relinquish mothering roles once they become incarcerated. When women serve time, they can no longer be directly responsible for day-to-day caregiving for their young children. Thus, children are often placed in the care of proxy caregivers. Notwithstanding, many women retain their maternal identities and wish to engage as mothers while they are incarcerated. As such, women must manage motherhood with and through their children's caregivers. Using group interviews, this study investigates how maternity is managed from prison with children's caregivers. Findings reveal the strategies women employ to maintain their role-identities as mothers while serving time. Policy implications are discussed.

KEYWORDS

Children's caregivers; identity management; incarcerated mothers; women in prison; mothers in prison; mothers and identity

INTRODUCTION

Motherhood can be a primary source of identity for women who have children. Through play, observation and interaction, girls often internalize social expectations that mothers be present and active as nurturers, emotionally supportive, and teachers to their children (Boyd, 1989; Bromberg, 1983; Grief, 1985). "Good" mothers are commended for their ability to provide direction, structure and discipline for their young. Historically, sociobiological explanations have presented mothering as the natural priority and inevitable destiny of women. Given this assumption, crime-involved women may be viewed as unfit, abhorrent, unnatural, violent and most dreadful among law violators, even when they commit nonviolent crimes (Baldwin, 2015; Lombroso et al., 1895; Merlo & Pollock, 2006). This belief persists despite the fact that many crime-involved women value their families and view motherhood as the most important part of their identity.

No mother is perfect, and imprisoned women are no exception (Boudin, 1998). The blueprint for conventional maternity lauds "intensive mothering," which requires mothers to selflessly expend a great deal of time, money and energy in rearing their children (Hays, 1996). Intensive mothers are expected to cope with the challenges of life with children without any difficulty or failure (Von Weller et al., 2018). However, "intensive mothering" may be an unrealistic, demoralizing, controlling and punishing standard for incarcerated women (Aiello, 2016; Aiello & McQueeney, 2019; Collins, 2000; Glenn et al., 1994). The celebration of this model also disparages the mothering practices of poor, working class and minority women (Aiello, 2016; Collins, 2000; Glenn et al., 1994), all of which are disproportionately represented among incarcerated women. Nonetheless, three quarters of these mothers were primary caretakers to their children prior to

incarceration (Bloom & Brown, 2011; Glaze & Maruschak, 2010; McGowan & Blumenthal, 1978; Green et al., 2000). Given that mothering implicates both *who* one is and *what* one does, imprisonment can upend the maternal role and threaten one's identity. Confined women are at a clear disadvantage when attempting to meet the physical and emotional demands of mothering. A mother serving time is with few exceptions separated by space and time from her children. Consequently, children are often placed in the care of proxy caregivers: grandparents, fathers, relatives, friends, and as a last resort foster care, to assume the role of caretaking in the physical absence of a mother (Enos, 2001).

Prisons as total institutions can isolate residents with rituals that effectively, and somewhat intentionally, strip women of their former identities and roles (Goffman, 1961). At intake, the incarcerated are relieved of personal effects and given a new identity: a number. Relics of their former life and identity can only be reclaimed once their time has been served. But reclamation of the maternal role is not easily accomplished if some semblance of it is not maintained during a woman's incarceration (Freudenberg et al., 2008). Prison mail and visitation policies, as well as cost prohibitive phone calls, make it difficult for women to maintain contact with the outside world where their children often remain (Hairston, 2007; Margolies & Kraft-Stolar, 2006). Mothers can go weeks, months and even years without seeing their children or hearing their voices (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Some prisons feature parenting and child visitation programs, but these solutions are far from perfect. Under such deleterious conditions, we might expect women to feel powerless and abandon maternal identities (Baunach, 1985).

Though obstacles to motherhood in prison can seem insurmountable, they may not be for women who cling to maternal identities. Women can be motivated by their children to survive "the cage," desist from crime (Brown & Bloom, 2009) and be innovative in ways that allow them to remain mothers. Some women find institutional support and allies to motherhood among other residents, prison staff and with the help of gender responsive programing (Aiello, 2016; Morash et al., 1998). These support systems, when they exist, can help women to manage mothering within the prison structure. However, the persons who care for a woman's children during her incarceration can be critical (Poehlmann et al., 2008). They may determine the nature of women's interactions with their children, and ultimately whether and how mothers *do* mothering while incarcerated (Enos, 2001). This study investigates how imprisoned women manage mothering role-identities through relationships with their children's caregivers.

MOTHERING ROLES AND IDENTITY: A THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Gendered role performance is often dictated by cultural expectations of behavior that are internalized through socialization processes that initiate in early childhood (Mangus, 1957). Roles such as that of a mother are usually learned through observation and imitation of significant others and can shape role performance in ways that tend to reflect social expectations (Biddle, 1986; Morgan & Schwalbe, 1990; Turner, 1991). Social roles are inclusive of what people do and ideas about what people *should* do when occupying particular social positions (Morgan & Schwalbe, 1990; Von Weller et al., 2018). However, whether by choice or circumstance, social actors do not always embody prescribed role expectations. Yet, once internalized and inhabited, roles can become central to a person's identity (Mangus, 1957). Thus, mothering, as a role-identity, is indicative of both identity and behavior (Von Weller et al., 2018). Yet a woman's perceptions about her ability to perform the maternal role in a socially acceptable way can shape her view of herself as a mother.

The management of role-identities can be a complex process in which people attempt to understand and negotiate who they are and how they fit into the scheme of things. The complexity of this process is exacerbated when an individual's social position changes unexpectedly or in a way that does not compliment role expectations. Such is the case when a mother goes to prison.

The successful (re)negotiation or eventual departure from a role-identity can be highly influenced by significant others. Indeed, the embodiment of any role-identity is shaped by interaction with significant others who can support or diminish the roles we play. Significant others are the persons whose care, opinions, affection and/or approval are especially desired (James, 1968; Kendall, 2012). As such, they are key to the development of the self and subsequent identity (Kendall, 2012).

Among incarcerated women, children's caregivers represent significant others whose opinions and approval matter. Caregivers' roles matter in terms of affection, a woman's ability to fulfill the mothering role and consequently the feelings women have about themselves as mothers. However, mothers are not passive consumers. When mothers perceive that their role-identities are viewed disparagingly, they may employ agency to engage in identity management. The notion of *agency* emphasizes the dynamic process by which individuals construct and claim their identities (McCall & Simmons, 1966; Stets & Burke, 2000). Depending on their social situation, people have varying degrees of freedom in devising for themselves the characters that comprise role-identity (Mangus, 1957; McCall & Simmons, 1966). While the power of human agency cannot be trivialized, the social structure's impact on human actors can far exceed an individual's impacts on the structure (Stryker, 1980). Prisons are the proverbial illustration of how a powerful social structure can diminish individual agency and shape the lives of its inhabitants.

The process of identity management often incorporates biographical narratives from social actors. These narratives can be used as tools to aid the individual in subverting deprecatory labels and negative self-feelings (Geiger & Fischer, 2003). These stories often retrospectively interpret life events to make sense of current conditions (Bruner, 1998). Likewise, narratives may minimize missteps, justify behavior or allow a person to take responsibility for their actions (Scott and Lyman, 1968), all while attempting to salvage or negotiate identity in the eyes of self and the social audience. Nonetheless, in the absence of role support, social actors may experience distress and difficulty in negotiating their roles (Burke, 1991; Stets & Burke, 2000).

In her study of imprisoned women, peer counselors, correctional officers, and prisons staff, Schram (1999) found that some women internalize and negatively react to criticism from staff about their mothering roles. This in turn can minimize mothers' attempts at role performance and endanger mother-child relationships. Schram's study offers evidence that mothers want to feel valued in their roles by people whose opinions and feelings they hold in high esteem. It can be assumed that when mothers choose their children's caregivers, they do so because among other things, they have some measure of respect or admiration for the persons they select. Thus, the degree to which women feel that their roles are valued and supported by caregivers as significant others may have important implications for whether and how they maintain their role-identities as mothers.

IMPRISONED MOTHERS

Policy agendas such as the war on drugs and truth in sentencing have dramatically increased the number of women in the criminal justice system (Crawford, 2003; Drug Policy Alliance, 2016; Sentencing Project, 2019). Are imprisoned women especially violent and dreadful as early criminologists theorized (Lombroso et al., 1895)? Are they unfit to mother? There is little empirical support for these ideas. Women comprise 8–10% of the prison population. Most are serving time for nonviolent offenses that are not necessarily related to child abuse, neglect or an inability to provide appropriate care for their children (Baldwin et al., 2015; Greenfield & Snell, 1999; Harrison & Beck, 2006; Snell & Morton, 1994). Women who are violent offenders are actually *less* likely to report being mothers (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). A study of 104 mothers participating in a 15-week parenting program found that there was no significant difference in parenting behaviors between mothers who had been convicted of crimes and those who had not

(Thompson & Harm, 2000). Thus, most imprisoned mothers do not fit dreadful typecasts and may, in fact, share many similarities with non-incarcerated mothers.

Imprisoned mothers must contend with the reality that someone else is responsible for day-to-day care of their children. This can be especially difficult for women who embrace intensive mothering. Children's caregiving arrangements can have important implications for a woman's role as a mother in the long and short-term. For younger children, caregivers can make simple, but significant decisions such as whether mothers and children talk by phone or correspond by mail. They can also determine whether children visit their mothers or participate in family programs when available (Poehlmann et al., 2010). In the long-term, caregiving arrangements can determine whether mothers will have legal custody or access to their children once they are released from prison. For children placed in the custody of the state or foster care, the likelihood that parental rights will be terminated may be exacerbated (Iskikian, 2019; Raimon et al., 2009; Smith, 2006). Incarcerated parents with children in foster care who have not abused, neglected or endangered their children are more likely to lose parental rights than parents who have physically or sexually assaulted their children (Iskikian, 2019). Further, previous research indicates that women's incarceration experience and post-incarceration outlook has implications for the salience of a mother's identity (Stringer & Barnes, 2012). Given these factors, the mother-caregiver relationship may be key to understanding the nature of mother-child relationships and maternal identity among imprisoned women.

CAREGIVING ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE CHILDREN OF INCARCERATED MOTHERS

Incarceration separates an estimated 147,400 dependent aged children in America from their mothers (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). Nearly 80% of these children are between 1 and 14 years of age (McGowan & Blumenthal, 1978; Morton & Williams, 1998; Sentencing Project, 2012). Incarcerated mothers most commonly identify grandmothers (45–50%) as their children's caregivers regardless of race or ethnicity (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010; Hill, 2003; Johnston, 1997; Philips & Gleeson, 2007; Sentencing Project, 2019). Following a mother's arrest, the number of children living in their father's care doubles—at least temporarily. Between 25% and 37% of children end up living with their fathers while their mothers serve time (Philips & Gleeson, 2007; Sentencing Project, 2012). Many of these fathers previously lived apart from their children. Though children may be placed in their father's care, it is not always clear who is responsible for the day-to-day care of children. According to Glaze and Maruschak (2010), fathers living with their young children often rely on others to provide daily care for them. Twenty-three percent (23%) of mothers report that their children are living with other relatives such as aunts or older siblings (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010; Sentencing Project, 2012). Not surprisingly, children living with kin report feeling greater love and safety than those living in foster care (Hairston, 1999). Incarcerated women who formed early positive attachments to their own mothers have more positive co-parenting experiences when children are placed with the mothers who raised them. This co-parenting relationship is marked by mutual support and more frequent contact with children (Loper & Clarke, 2013). As such, grandparents and other relative caregivers are often preferred by imprisoned mothers (Enos, 2001).

Though kinship care is often preferred, it may not be without its challenges. Caregivers often struggle to foster relationships between children and their incarcerated parents (Margolies & Kraft-Stolar, 2006). Caregivers may also feel shame, anger, stress and financial strain when a mother goes to prison (Johnston, 1997; Travis & Solomon, 2003). A mother's incarceration can constitute an adverse childhood experience with cumulative effects, including children feeling conflicted between their mother and caregivers, emotional disturbances, damaged self-esteem, an increased risk for childhood delinquency and future imprisonment (Bloom & Steinhart, 1993; Greenburg, 2006; Henriques, 1982; Johnston, 1997; McGowan & Blumenthal, 1978; Morton &

Williams, 1998; Poehlmann, 2005b; Turney, 2018). According to Poehlmann (2005a, 2005b), knowing that their children have stability, emotional and behavioral support is helpful for a mother who is coping with incarceration.

INCARCERATED MOTHERS' RELATIONSHIPS WITH CAREGIVERS

A lack of daily involvement with their children is cited as one of the most challenging aspects of incarceration among women (Ingram-Fogel, 1993). Poehlmann (2005a) found that when mothers and caregivers have relationships marked by conflict, there is less visitation and phone contact with children. However, when mothers and caregivers agree upon their roles, their relationships fare better and children are more likely to experience continuity in care, rather than being moved between households (Johnston, 1997). Thus, the relationship between mothers and their children's caregivers can have implications for children's well-being as well as a woman's relationship with her children (Poehlmann, 2005a; Poehlmann et al., 2008). Yet few studies investigate the practical strategies that women use to manage motherhood in concert with their children's caregivers. This is the primary task undertaken in the present study. Using group interview data from incarcerated mothers, the ways in which mother-caregiver relationships impact the mothering role-identity are explored.

Mothering among incarcerated women cannot be romanticized. Often, the aggregate effects of women's abuse, addiction, poverty and trauma can inhibit or attenuate mothering role-identities even before incarceration. Not all incarcerated mothers are committed to motherhood and some may relinquish these roles if they are unable to reconcile caregiver relationships, past behavior or their present contexts with mothering. While caregivers and the prison structure itself can erect barriers to performing maternal roles, this study is an investigation of the ways in which women, with varying degrees of success, attempt to manage these roles and maintain their identities as mothers. Group interviews with imprisoned women are used as a means of drawing out mothers' biographical sketches and motherhood narratives (Geiger & Fischer, 2003) in order to better understand how they manage the maternal role-identity.

METHODS

Research Site

With the approval of the University's Institutional Review Board and the state's Department of Correction, a three-part study was conducted at a Midwest women's prison. The components of the study include a survey of the entire prison population, group interviews with mothers and participant observation in the prison's parenting program. The present study draws upon data collected during group interviews with mothers. While complete demographic data is not available for group interview participants, findings from the survey administered to the entire prison population show that nearly 73% of the residents have biological, adopted and/or foster children. Sixty-three percent (63%) report living with their children prior to incarceration. These findings align with existing research suggesting that many imprisoned women are mothers and are significantly involved in their children's daily lives prior to incarceration (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010).

Sample and Procedures

This study is based on group interviews with a purposive convenience sample. Group interviews are used in order to give women voice and gain first-hand, in depth knowledge of women's maternal experiences. Women were primarily recruited through flyers posted in housing units and announcements made by the researcher during the survey administration. Group interviews

Table 1. Age for prison population.

Age	
Mean	42 years
Mode	21 years
Median	34 years
Range	16–79 years
Total population $N = 288$.	

Table 2. Marital status of prison population.

Marital status	%	N
Single/Never Married	44	127
Single/Cohabiting	10	30
Married	11	32
Separated	8	23
Divorced	17	50
Widowed	7	20
Mothers in population	73	210
Total population $N = 288$.		

Table 3. Offense categories of the prison population.

Offense categories	%	N
Drug offenses	20	58
Violent offenses	44	126
Sex offenses	5	15
Property offenses	15	43
Economic offenses	9	35
Other	5	15
Recidivists	26	76
Serving time for multiple offenses	38	108
Total population $N = 288$.		

were conducted in prison classrooms. No guards or prison staff were present. Each mother was asked to select a pseudonym as not to be identified in transcripts or future publications. Participants were compensated with a child’s stationary kit which included colored paper and stickers for writing letters to children. All participants were advised of the voluntary nature of group interviews and gave their written consent to participate.

Two women moderators conducted nine, one-hour group interviews with approximately 55 women. The number of participants in each group varied between five to ten women. The sample is comprised of women who are mothers, grandmothers and great grandmothers. One aunt who co-parented with her siblings prior to her incarceration is also included in the sample. About 49% ($n = 27$) are identified as White, and 23% ($n = 13$) are identified as African American. Three percent (3%) of the sample is identified as multiracial and 3% are identified as Hispanic ($n = 4$). Twenty percent (20%) ($n = 11$) of respondent’s races could not be identified. On average, respondents have 2.9 children (biological, adopted and/or foster). At the time of data collection, women had served between 2 months and 24 years on their current sentence, though women were not asked to report the length of their sentences. Neither were participants asked directly about their marital status, age or crimes. However, demographic data was collected in the survey administered to the entire prison population from which the sample is drawn. These data are presented in Tables 1–3.

Data Analysis

Moderators used an open-ended discussion guide for all group interviews. This format allows respondents to build narratives and discourse around the issues and experiences most important

to them. As such, mothers have the opportunity to tell their own stories, from their perspective, on their own terms (Gubrium & Holstein, 1997). Such narratives can be key to the management of role identities (Bruner, 1998; Geiger & Fischer, 2003). The open-ended guide also allows the moderator to clarify respondents' intentions, beliefs, and attitudes, while allowing for inter-group comparisons (Kerlinger, 1964).

Group interviews were audio-taped, transcribed and analyzed using content analysis. Data analysis is initially based on pre-coded themes contrived from the research questions and the literature. However, new themes emerge during analysis. In coding and analysis, the researcher breaks down the narratives generated in group interviews and arranges them in ways that allow for the creation of new categories and their relationships to one another (Maxwell, 2009). During the process, the researcher moves back and forth between conceptualization, analysis and interpretation (Altheide, 2004), being careful to center the language respondents use and the meaning conveyed through words and affect. Special consideration is given to the experiences and topics that respondents emphasize as important. Finally, the researcher is sensitive to the ways in which the meaning of specific experiences and motherhood in general is constructed within the context of the group (Bryman, 2004). Findings along with representative quotes from respondents are presented below.

FINDINGS

Caregiving Arrangements

Sample mothers agreed that surrendering the care of their children to other individuals was often a painful transition. Lexus, a White mother of two sons states:

[I'm] going through all this therapy and self-help groups to feel better, to not have low self-esteem, to become a healthier person. Yet I feel inadequate in the fact that someone else is taking care of my child.

Other women shared this view. Christa is an African American mother of three girls. She delivered her youngest daughter while incarcerated, only six weeks prior to our meeting. She relays,

... (crying) I'll be ok. This is going to be one of my harder times.... Because... I love my kids. My kids are with me all the time. I didn't plan on being incarcerated so my mom could raise my kids cause that's not her job, it was mine.

It is clear from these representative quotes that sample women have internalized conventional expectations that mothers be present and accounted for in the daily lives of their children. While separation from their children is a stark reality that shapes their maternal experiences, so too do children's specific living arrangements.

Mothers were asked to speak about their children's living arrangements since their incarceration. A range of surrogate caregivers are represented among respondents. Given cultural expectations about women as caretakers, it is not surprising that women most often assume caregiving for respondents' children. Eighty-two percent (82%) of respondents reported that at least one of their children's caregivers was another woman. Maternal grandmothers, followed by other persons with whom mothers have a familial relationship, are the most frequently reported caregivers. However, the number of fathers who took on caregiving responsibilities is not insignificant. Thirty-three percent (33%) of respondents said that children's fathers assumed caregiving for at least one of their children. While relative caretakers are most common, a small proportion of mothers report that their children are in non-familial caregiving arrangements with friends, foster or adoptive parents. Mothers' comments suggest that this option is employed when family members are unwilling or unable to take on the responsibility of caregiving. Helen, a White mother of five children, spoke about her only dependent-aged child: "He's in a foster home right now... I

just had that done ...cause I didn't have nobody. My mother, she's dead...I didn't have nobody else."

In some families, caregiving responsibilities are delegated among multiple persons. Mothers are more commonly report multiple caregivers in families with multiple children or multiple fathers. Women also report unique challenges associated with multiple caregivers. Lexus sadly shares her experiences with her sons:

They're separated. They see each other at their visits here every other week and sometimes their dad's will get together maybe once a month and let them spend the night. But up until almost 3 years ago when I got arrested, they had never lived outside of one another... So not only are they dealing with the separation of me being incarcerated, they're dealing with the separation of being apart from one another.

Justina is a White mother of three children. Each child has a different caregiving arrangement in three different cities. She states:

I'm in my fourth year...I haven't seen all of my children at one time except for [once] since I've been down... and they don't get to see each other ...very often. All of my children aren't by the same father... My mom had to take my son, or my son was going to end up in foster care, because I had my son here... Of course she loves him, but she got sick. That's why he's with a friend of the family. Nobody... let[s] my kids see their siblings... so it's kind of hard.

Like Justina, many incarcerated mothers may feel challenged by their children's caregiving arrangements, especially when their children are living in separate households. Women's narratives suggest that the separation of their children into separate households creates difficulty in maintaining both maternal and sibling relationships. The maintenance of the maternal role is also complicated by variations in the perceived quality of care their children receive. When children are divided across different households, mothers must manage their roles with multiple persons, and disperse their emotional energy and resources across multiple households and caregivers. It can become increasingly difficult to remain bonded and active in the lives of all their children. Women can feel a double pang of guilt because incarceration has caused their children to lose both their mother and their siblings. Here, respondents illuminate an often-understated part of the mothering role: the pressure that mothers feel to keep their offspring relationally bonded to one another. As illustrated by Justina's comments, this becomes more difficult in multiple caregiver arrangements. However, when a mother chooses her children's caregiving arrangements, she may more easily manage her maternal role with and among caregivers.

The Power to Choose: Making Caregiver Arrangements for Children

Having some authority in choosing their children's caregiver seemed to ameliorate some of the challenges of separation and feelings of inadequacy. However, the degree of agency in choosing their children's caregivers varies among women. Mothers describe ideal caregiving arrangements as placements that keep children within the family. Interestingly, women's narratives reveal that "the family" was a term which almost exclusively referred to a mother's relatives rather than persons related to their children's fathers. In other words, keeping children within the mother's family was a priority. Maternal grandmothers were often preferred with other maternal relatives as a secondary choice. Women believe that these are persons with whom they share parenting ideals and whose decisions will often reflect their own wishes concerning children. A woman may also perceive that her relatives already share a meaningful relationship and care deeply for her children. Likewise, family members tend to have an affection for the incarcerated woman as a mother and as a person. As such these caregivers are perceived as being more open to supporting women as they manage mothering while incarcerated. This seems to set the stage for a woman's ability to effectively manage the maternal role-identity with caregivers. While speaking about her children's living arrangements, Beonka, an African American mother of two girls living with their maternal

grandmother, says, “I wouldn’t have it any other way...I want my children to stay within the family.”

Notwithstanding women’s preference for her relatives to care for children, women may admire fathers who willingly accept responsibility for their children. Despite the challenges of negotiating motherhood with two caregivers, Lexus says of her children’s fathers, “They’re good fathers... each one of their dads wanted them and they wanted that responsibility.” When fathers have legal custody of their offspring, it is not always clear who is responsible for the day-to-day care of children. This mimics results found in other research (Glaze & Maruschak, 2010). It is clear from some respondents’ narratives that mothers do not always acknowledge or know about women with whom fathers may have temporary or ongoing relationships or arrangements. These women may be responsible for providing or assisting in childcare. This truth was illuminated by Dee Dee, an African American mother who was expecting her third child at the time of data collection. She spoke about a recent phone conversation with her daughter:

[My husband] has this mistress, whoever she might be. My daughter knows her as mother...but... [my daughter] ...knows I’m her mama and she tells me everything. And I think [my husband] does not like that because she’s only three ...when I talked to her today, she was like, “Let me talk to my mama.” And she got on the phone...She said, “We got pictures taken.” I said, “Who?” “Me, and my daddy and my mama...”

That Dee Dee’s child references her husband’s mistress as mama suggests the possibility that the mistress may have a significant caregiving role for Dee Dee’s daughter. Dee Dee’s tone and subsequent verbiage indicate that this was a direct threat to her maternal identity. This case also illuminates that incarcerated mothers must manage motherhood with designated caregivers as well as other “mothers” in their children’s lives. African American mothers in the sample are especially concerned about who their children know as “mama.” They delineate the contexts in which this is acceptable, such as when children use the term to refer to maternal grandmothers and aunts. Ironically, Dee Dee encountered a second mistress in the prison who relayed that she too had been involved with Dee Dee’s husband for a time, and that the child was often in her care. These circumstances, while far beyond the control of any incarcerated mother, can dramatically impact whether and how she manages her mothering role-identity. Dee Dee’s case also demonstrates that while women may exercise agency to manage their children’s living arrangements, they cannot negotiate the precise terms of that arrangement.

Some mothers are limited in their options or have no options at all as to what will happen with their children when they become incarcerated. Women whose children are not placed with relatives often express reluctance and resentment regarding the arrangement. V, an African American mother of three girls was expecting her fourth child, a baby girl, at the time of data collection. She shares her feelings of disappointment about her children having to live with a friend:

So I’m down here with my children and all my family is up there. So basically all [my children] know is me. So by me being incarcerated, it makes it a lot harder on them than say if you had a cousin or auntie or something like that, a sister or whatever. I mean, you know, some close family that you can go to... So my children are with a friend of mine.

LaShaunna, an African American mother, also had little choice in her children’s living arrangements. Her sister chose for her two daughters to live with another sister in Kentucky until they completed high school. Her sister then moved the girls to Florida to live with an uncle and attend college. LaShaunna, a professed Christian, supports her sister’s choice because her children live in a religious environment that values education, as she does. However, she has not seen her children since her incarceration and rarely has phone contact with them or other relatives. LaShaunna’s case is exemplary in that a lack of agency in arranging caregiving seems to coincide with a diminished ability to maintain contact or successfully manage an ongoing role in children’s lives.

In some ways, LaShaunna is an anomaly. She presents as very supportive of those who raised and now support her children. However, among respondents, most women who do not choose their children's caregivers, do not support the living arrangements or the caregivers. For example, Nichole, an African American mother of three boys, does not support the decision that her brother and mother made to place two of her children with their father. Nichole views this as a poor choice that exposes her children to an inappropriate lifestyle and an environment with little structure. Nichole relays that the children's father makes no effort to facilitate or support her relationship with her children. Similarly, Janey, a White mother of six children, was disappointed when her children's living arrangement was altered by an overburdened caregiver, resulting in the separation of her three small children into two different households in two different states. Janey said of her informally adopted child with special needs,

I knew when I took custody of [my son] that he would have problems learning ... My sister ... feels like she couldn't handle that with the other two [children] ... [She says,] I'm not as strong as you. And so I don't agree about [her] sending [my son] to live in Kentucky with [my other sister] ... See originally the three little ones were together. Then she said, Janey, I can't do that. I said, Well I don't agree. But I wouldn't want him any other place but with my other sister.

In her final analysis, what was most important to Janey is that her son stayed within "the family," or with maternal relatives. Though mothers like Janey may not be entirely satisfied with living arrangements, they may feel that it is best not to resist, lest they create tension between caregivers and themselves. If women like LaShaunna, V, and Janey can't *choose* their children's caregivers, the next best option is to *approve* of the arrangements that others have made. This was a part of an overarching strategy to *go along to get along* and remain in caregivers' good graces. To neither *choose* nor *approve* of children's caregivers seems to be an indication of a woman's limited agency and power to manage her maternal role-identity with caregivers. Conversely, the power to choose the person who cares for their children seems to predict the degree of agency women can employ to have access, an active role, or even authority in the lives of their children.

Having Authority as a Mother

In the study, mothers who exercise authority in their children's lives make decisions about children's caregiving, education, and/or extracurricular activities. For instance, Tammy, an African American mother of three, chose for her youngest daughter to live with her mother. Consequently, she has been able to act as a disciplinarian and decision maker in her daughter's life. In reference to her daughter, Tammy illustrates her parental authority:

When she gets in trouble at school, I do have talks with her. She's not getting her work done in school, so now I'm letting her stay after school ... [W]hen she was in the first grade, and the teachers was talking about ... keeping her in the first grade ... I told them yeah gone ahead and keep her back.

Likewise, Jaime a White mother, decided that her only child, an autistic daughter, would live with her parents. She recounts how she used her authority and influence as a mother to get her child the help she needs:

My daughter was sexually molested, and she has a lot of issues with that ... So, I had to start talking to my family again a couple months ago because I started noticing issues with her on her visits. I talked to my parents to get her back in therapy, which they've started her therapy again.

Toni, a White mother, made arrangements for her only child to live with his maternal grandmother, who allows her to exercise a great deal of authority in his life:

I wrote Big Brothers Big Sisters and he's got a big sister right now that's my age and she does a lot of the same things I do. I wrote Boys and Girls Club so he's going there after school to do structured activities

and keep him ... hopefully on the right path ... And then my church here, I've even gotten him involved in the church in his area. So, we're learning about the same things

Women who exercise some degree of agency and authority appear to more strongly assert their identities as mothers. They often report better quality relationships with their children than mothers who have little or no choice in choosing their children's caregivers. Exercising such authority allows women to make a claim on maternal identity and thus functions as maternal management tool. It can signal to the caregiver and others that a woman is a key player in her children's lives. Further, the ability to identify and help meet a child's needs conveys that a mother is knowledgeable, irreplaceable and that the mother-child bond persists. Though data on the ages of group interview respondents was not collected, women who appeared to be younger in age (estimated to be in their late teens and early twenties) seemed to have far less authority in their children's lives, and to be more comfortable transferring most or all authority to caregivers. Corey, a multi-racial mother, is an example. She gave birth to her only child, a son, while serving her current sentence, and has never provided full-time primary care for him. Her older sister has been raising him since his birth. Corey's comments are informative.

Moderator: Are you consulted about decisions regarding your son?

Corey: No ... But she'll do what's best. Like if I want to do something then I'll let her know. She will agree to it. But like ... school stuff, she'll make the best decision and ... She's real picky and that's the way I want her to be with my son. If it's safe and looks alright and clean ...

While Corey is not consulted about decisions regarding her son, she appears comfortable in allowing her sister to perform this role. She also reserves the role of disciplinarian for her sister. While other mothers spoke of grounding, placing children in time-outs or having talks when they misbehaved, Corey said, "He's with me right now ... I hate to see him cry ... just let him be a little bad boy ... Let him do what he wants." Corey receives very few visits from her son which she attributes to her sister's procrastination. Thus, she prefers that her sister discipline the child, though not in her presence. Nonetheless, the pattern is clear: women who have limited authority are often limited in other aspects of mothering such as discipline and spending time with their children. Though Corey's maternal role is unconventional in many ways, her maternal identity does not seem to be compromised by this arrangement. She views herself as a mother and demonstrates the salience of that identity throughout her narrative.

Getting along: The Impact of Mother-Caregiver Relationships

Upon assuming the responsibility of caring for children, caregivers gain influence in the mother-child relationship. Caregivers can determine the type (visits, letters, phone calls), quality and frequency of interaction between mothers and their children. Essentially, caregivers become gatekeepers of mother-child relationships and greatly influence how mothers perform their role. Among respondents, the quality of the mother-caregiver relationship bespeaks the degree to which caregivers and mothers get along. Women describe good relationships as those in which mothers and caregivers are mutually supportive and work together to pursue the best interest of children. Angel, an African American mother to three sons demonstrates her support for her children's caregiver.

[I] make sure that they ... are obeying my mother. If they get in trouble with my mom, she tells me everything and I have a conversation with them and tell them don't do it and they don't do it.

Mothers often offer role support by admonishing their children to comply and cooperate with caregivers. This support seems to be generously offered when caregivers are perceived to possess

values and parenting practices that mothers approve. Lindsay, a White mother of three children, demonstrates role support for her mother who cares for her children:

My mom and I have always been on the same brain wave of discipline ... And my six-year-old tried to tell me, "My Nanna spanked me one day" and I said, if your Nana spanked you, you deserved it ... Right now, she's doing a chart with my six-year-old and when she gets so many stars ... she gets to pick if she wants to go out ... So I agree.

Like many mothers and daughters, Lindsay and her mother hold similar parenting values. Mothers often socialize their daughters for mothering roles, so it is logical that many mother-daughter dyads share parenting practices and ideals. This is apparent among many respondents who report high levels of support for their mothers in their caregiving roles.

Conversely, incarcerated mothers may withdraw support when caregivers do not share their parenting values and practices. Women often assess such caregivers as incompetent and unsupportive of them as mothers. Kris, a White mother of five children, describes a problematic situation with one of her children's caregivers:

My grandmother has my three [middle] children in California ... She doesn't want to lose them. But she's 82 years old and they tell *her* what to do ... I told her ... you can't keep letting them tell you what to do. I'm going to have to bring them back to _____, and somebody else is going to have to keep them ... And uh, my grandmother is very wealthy ... and I'm not. She ... allows them to get whatever they want ... And I try to tell her that's not good ... because when I come home, I'm not going to be able to buy my children ... they're not going to be able to go to the shelf and pick whatever they want out, because I don't have that kind of money that you have ... You're teaching them that they can have whatever they want in life. And it's not always going to be like that.

Kris doesn't believe her grandmother is capable of providing her children with the boundaries, discipline and structure they need. She also feels that her parenting values are undermined when her grandmother spoils the children and spares them from the reality of what life will be like when Kris resumes care. As a result, she withdraws support. Capitalizing upon her grandma's fear of losing the children, Kris threatens to remove them from her care. Given that an 82-year-old is presently caring for three young children, it seems unlikely that Kris has other caregiver options. Yet it is not possible to know whether Kris' perceived agency is feigned, imagined or real. However, it is clear from other women's narratives that the level of authority Kris implies is far more extreme than what other respondents experience. For most women, caregivers seem to wield the greatest power in the mother-child-caregiver triad. Yet Kris's narrative is noteworthy, reminding us that perceptions, meaning, narratives and perhaps even memories about mothering, are constructed by individuals within the context of the group. These dynamics, even at the extreme, are part and parcel to understanding more about how incarcerated women manage their role-identities.

Though the role support mothers offer to caretakers is important, the support that caregivers can offer, or withhold appears to be far more influential to women's identities and mother-child relationships. Caregivers who offer role support to incarcerated mothers recognize them as viable mothers, rather than absentee parents. Supportive caregivers acknowledge and advocate a mother's role with children and institutions (i.e. schools) as an active authority figure, nurturer, emotional support, as well as other conventional dimensions of motherhood. Birdie, an African American mother of two, describes a situation involving her caregiving sister and her daughter:

I told my daughter ... I don't want you to have no little boyfriend until I come home. And she was like, "Well, mom you can't do that." I was like, "I'm your mother." She said, "Well I'll just ask my auntie." So, my sister said, "... what did your mother say?" And she said, "Well, my mom said I couldn't have a boyfriend until she comes home." [My sister] said, "Well that's final."

While some caregivers offer role support only on occasion, mothers suggest that quality relationships with caregivers are marked by regular and consistent support. Mothers feel most supported when caregivers regularly allow children to visit and participate in family programs at the

prison. These events provide opportunities for mothers and children to reacquaint, bond and experience some similitude of normal family life. Mothers also describe supportive caregivers as those that encourage children to write letters and allow them to have regular phone contact with their mothers as a means of maintaining quality relationships. Mother-child contact has been found to influence mothering attitudes among incarcerated women (Barnes & Stringer, 2014).

Strategies for Maintaining Good Relationships with Caregivers: Cooperation and Communication

Though role support should ideally be reciprocal, mothers acknowledge that the burden of maintaining good relationships with their children's caregivers largely falls upon them. Before becoming incarcerated many of the women in the study were unaccustomed to consulting other persons regarding their children. Thus, learning to compromise with caregivers is a challenge. V, who describes herself as selfish with her children says:

I have been in that situation [with my children's caregiver] where ... you really don't have a say so. And that's what makes it hard because I like to be in control of everything, especially pertaining to my children.

Women described cooperation as the degree to which a caregiver is willing to work together to make major decisions about their children. Though cooperation is by definition reciprocal, many mothers find that they must do most of the yielding in order to maintain a good relationship with caregivers. For instance, V continues:

... In a situation like this ... you have to agree to disagree. Give your side of the situation. Maybe you can come to a mutual agreement. I didn't want my daughter to go to Alabama with her father. But [her caregiver] was like, "If her daddy come over here, I'm not gone [sic] keep her away from her daddy" ... It's hard to still be a mama and be up in here.

Like V, mothers can feel like they are at the mercy of their children's caregivers when it comes to their mothering roles. Working with non-familial caregivers can often present an additional challenge. Janise, a White mother, battled with her son's adoptive mother for 1 year before learning to cooperate. Janise relays:

She could have just taken him. But instead, after fighting for a year and threatening the judges and everything over it, we made friends. Now [my son] visits and I just signed him over to her ...

Open communication is also key to maintaining good relationships with their children's caregivers. Respondents described good communication as openness on the part of caregivers to communicate about issues and events that transpire with their children. Most mothers want to be informed on the day-to-day details of their children's lives. Christa, an African American mother says:

I keep in contact with my mom. I probably call her once a week and she lets me know what my two-year old is doing ... I mean you know she keeps me pretty posted on ... what they do ...

Several mothers attribute their enhanced ability to communicate and have positive relationships with caregivers to the parenting classes they take in the prison's family program. For example, Andrea, a relatively young Hispanic mother of one son speaks about her initial difficulty in communicating with her child's caregiver. She says:

The people that take care of my child, they're businesspeople and they're always out of town and traveling so, it's like I found it hard to like ask them to bring my son more often cause I feel like they did already too much. The classes I have taken has [sic] helped me to communicate with them more than [I] used to ...

Breakdowns in communication and cooperation can create anxiety, frustration and fewer mothering opportunities for sample mothers. Shaleah, a White mother of two explains:

... I write my son a letter every week and [his father] won't write me back to tell me how he's doing ... He likes to move and not tell my family where he moves. So now it's like a cat and mouse game.

Here, women's narratives suggest that role support is not always reciprocated by children's caregivers. Respondents often reported perceptions that their children's fathers are the least supportive caregivers. Women's narrative accounts of their frustration, anger and sadness regarding a lack of support from their children's caregivers make clear that these experiences are damaging to a mother's role-identity.

Something to Prove

For women dealing with incarceration, addiction and trauma, mothering can feel like "an all or nothing ultimatum (p. 59)." Thus, mothers may feel the need to prove to themselves, their children, as well as social audiences that they are "good" mothers. (Enos, 2001; Von Weller et al., 2018, p. 59). Mothers who find themselves in difficult circumstances may make comparisons between themselves and others as a means of preserving and negotiating their own maternal identities (Bemiller, 2005). According to McQueeney (2009), women make claims on motherhood to persuade others that they are morally deserving. Among moms in the sample, a strategy used to prove maternal fitness and preserve the maternal identity is the comparison of themselves to their children's caregivers. For many, these comparisons affirm their identity, even when contradictions in their narratives seem apparent. For others, the comparison of themselves to their children's caregivers and other mothers finds them lacking by their own accounts. In these cases, maternal identity may be attenuated. Conversely, comparisons can frame *caregivers* as unfit, a designation that seems to be reserved for caregivers with whom mothers have poor relationships and receive little support. For instance, Dee Dee concedes that her child's father, the primary caregiver, is active in her daughter's life. Yet, she judges him as deficient in his paternal role. Though this may seem like a contradiction, she explains,

He's active in her life twenty-four hours a day...but he's not a good father to her because she's not stable ... they look down on me because I'm incarcerated, and I have a drug problem ... But my thing is he's a whore.... He sleeps around and my baby is being drug from here to there... My child aint on Medicaid.... You know, you're lacking in the areas where she needs things... Why come she ain't in no daycare?... She's too smart for you not to have her in school. Ok she hangs around adults twenty-four hours a day. Where's the kids at? ... She's not getting nothing other than street knowledge ... from adults.

By identifying her husband's deficiencies, Dee Dee demonstrates to her social audience as well as herself that she is a good mother. Further, when compared to her husband, *she* is the competent parent who knows how to provide stability, protection, education and appropriate socialization for her child. Though Dee Dee discloses during interviews that she struggles with addiction and is currently serving time for a prostitution case, this does not seem to disqualify her as a mother. She affirms her maternal role-identity by being knowledgeable of what good parents do and provide for their children. Being knowledgeable about their children and childrearing in general becomes evidence in women's case to prove that they are worthy mothers. Likewise, when sample mothers see themselves as meeting prescribed maternal expectations, or as having done so in the past, their maternal identity is affirmed.

Still other women view themselves, rather than others as deficient. When women don't feel that they measure up to social expectations, the maternal identity can be diminished. This can lead women to relinquish the maternal role and may be more likely when mothers believe that caregivers as more competent and capable parents. Kayla, a White mother of four admits:

I lived a drug life. And I'm not saying just as a user, but a lot of drugs back in my home ... I chose that it was just best that my children were not around me... My daughter is 17. She asked me when she was about 12 years old, she said, Mom, please don't make me choose between you and dad, because that's what I'll have to do. And I didn't make her choose. I made the choice because I didn't want to hurt my child that way. I'd rather stay out of her life. I'm not going to have my child put through, so I stay out of it.

She's got college, she's got everything. She doesn't need me. She might need the love of a mother but doesn't need my lifestyle. She's better off where she's at.

Beonka, thinking about her addiction, maternal failures and perceived powerlessness also feels that she doesn't measure up:

I can give advice. And I can be an example. This (motioning to indicate the prison) is what happens if you step out of line. But other than that, there's nothing I can do ... I haven't been a good example in the past. Those kids aren't stupid. They know what I was doing ... I used to say, "Do as I say, don't do as I do," but you see what I'm doing ... That's why I said I have to be an example. This is what happens.

Beonka relays that because of what she sees as her repeated moral and maternal failings, her oldest daughter has emerged as the mother of their family. Beonka believes that her daughter measures up to motherhood more so than she does. As such, she appears to resign herself to the role of a dependent rather than a mother. Beonka continues,

She's ... 19 ... She's got the mind of a woman for such a young child. She's very intelligent, she's very mature. She takes care of [my mother]. She's mama to my little girl. The little girl don't like it, but she has to answer to her. When I look at it, she has more sense than I do because [of how] she's carrying herself ...

The narratives of Kayla and Beonka demonstrate that mothering is not being romanticized among respondents. Their narratives also demonstrate Bruner's (1998) point that within narratives we find retrospective interpretations of past choices and events that help to make sense of the present. While many women experience hard won victories in the journey of mothering while incarcerated, some women, in their own estimations, do not measure up. In such cases, instead of managing motherhood, women may relinquish their identities and their parenting role to others whom they perceive to be more capable. In thinking about the sample mothers whose maternal identities were diminished, one cannot help but think about the ways in which conventional ideas about maternity can be harmful and set unrealistic expectations about what motherhood can and should be. For instance, Kayla's belief that her daughter is better off without her could be an impediment to her recovery as well as lead to other harmful behaviors and experiences for both mother and daughter.

CONCLUSION

While a mother's incarceration can separate her from her children, it does not necessarily mean the end of motherhood. Women in this study care deeply for their children and continue to perform and identify as mothers. Rather than the antitheses of mothering, many women are resilient and determined to mother their children. Though the small convenience sample limits the generalizability of the findings, mothers' narratives enhance our understanding of what it means to mother in a carceral context. Most participants continue to identify as mothers and work to manage the mothering role-identity in concert with their children's caregivers. While previous studies document the challenges of mothering while incarcerated (Enos, 2001; Clark, 1995; Thompson & Harm, 2000; Young & Smith, 2000) this study enhances our understanding about some of the strategies women employ to manage their role-identities as mothers while imprisoned. These strategies include making living arrangements for their children, working to maintain quality relationships through cooperation, communication and a willingness to support their children's caregivers. These women are on a mission to prove that they are good mothers despite their past mistakes and misfortunes.

A theoretical framework of mothering roles and identity (role-identity) is useful for framing women's management of the mothering role in a non-normative space like prison. Women's narratives demonstrate a desire to measure up to both personal and social expectations of motherhood. This bespeaks the salience of the maternal identity in many women's lives. However, a smaller group of mothers like Kayla and Beonka, seem to have all but given up on mothering

one or more of their children. Yet, women's stories illuminate the ways in which they can use personal agency, however limited, to influence and remain active in the lives of their children. Women's agency is tempered not just by the prison structure itself, but also by caregivers whose opinions and support matter greatly to mothers behind bars.

Group interviews lift and center women's voices and lead to an in-depth understanding of women's experiences. Women's narratives reveal biographical sketches of their lives and relationships with their children and caregivers. Moreover, group interviews reveal how the narrative itself can become a tool for identity management. In Kris's narrative about her children's 82-year old caregiver and her threat to make other living arrangements for them, the narrative itself appears to be used as a tool for Kris to present herself as a mother with unrequited authority and power to command the affairs of her children. Likewise, among other mothers who speak about their children's living arrangements, it becomes clear that the power to choose and approve their children's caregivers is key to managing motherhood while behind bars. This strategy is crucial since caregivers act as gatekeepers to mother-child relationships, and can facilitate or inhibit a mother's engagement and bond with her children. The degree to which women feel valued and supported by caregivers can determine how they function and identify as mothers. Caregivers who support mothers in their roles can simultaneously help solidify the maternal identity. Caregivers who are perceived as unwilling to extend maternal support are the source of significant role strain, which can, in turn, destabilize the mothering role-identity.

Women also strategically use comparison as a means of proving their competence in their roles as mothers. While society and children's caregivers may view incarcerated women as unfit to parent, women are not passive consumers of these labels. Having some authority, possessing knowledge about their children, the ability to discern children's needs and knowing what it takes to be a good parent empowers many women to believe, "I am enough" when it comes to mothering their children. This positive trend among some mothers may be in no small part owing to the prison's family program. The program emphasizes the needs of children, a child-centered lifestyle, parental bonding, effective discipline techniques, family communication, budgeting and other family life skills. Thus, women's resolve to maintain their role-identities despite difficulty and contradiction may be an indication of how family programs can support positive maternal identities.

While this study is informative and effectual in augmenting the knowledge we have about incarcerated mothers' experiences, it has its limitations. Namely, the findings are based on a purposive convenience sample of 55 women. These women may not be representative of the prison itself, or incarcerated women in general. Yet, a range of experiences is represented among sample mothers. While some mothers boast great successes in mothering while incarcerated, others have fledgling maternal role-identities. This is evidence that sample mothers are not merely romanticizing their experiences. As such, there is a healthy confidence in the validity of the findings.

In the prison population from which the sample was drawn, 18% of women report that parental rights to their children have already been terminated while 25% do not expect to have custody of their children upon release. What, if any, are the collateral consequences of permanent social and legal separation for incarcerated mothers and children? Can these relationships be preserved for the benefit of both mothers and children? What role can proxy caregivers play in enhancing the lives of children and mothers? These and other questions must be empirically investigated to discern the best way forward for programs and policies that target incarcerated mothers and their families.

In addition, correctional institutions in America must universally commit to progressive, evidence-based rehabilitation for incarcerated women. Most incarcerated mothers will eventually return to their communities. Given the central role that many women play in their families, prisons must pledge to provide women with the services and skills they need to be better as individuals, but also better family members (Peterson et al., 2018). Findings suggest that incarcerated women, their children and their children's caregivers need access to programs that: teach and encourage healthy family communication; promote positive co/parenting; and provide

opportunities to create healthy and meaningful relationships in difficult circumstances. Programs must acknowledge that a mother's incarceration does not in and of itself place children and families at risk, but also poverty, mental illness and a lack of social support for these conditions are also culprits (Peterson et al., 2018; Turney & Wildeman, 2015). Programs must address these precipitating issues to effectively restore families and communities. Programs must also develop inclusive curriculums that reflect the various parenting styles and realities of the women they serve. While intensive mothering indicates a significant investment of time, money and emotional labor into childrearing (Hays, 1996), justice-involved women have historically been marginalized by race, gender inequities and class. Thus, they tend to lack access to the social supports required for these mothering models (Collins, 1994, 2000; Hays, 2003). Further, women in prison are disproportionately racial ethnic minorities whose cultures often emphasize mothering attributes that differ from convention (Collins, 1994). For instance, single African American mothers may emphasize protection and teaching children to be self-reliant rather than dependent upon parents or other caretakers (Elliott et al., 2015). Effective programs must take into consideration these and various other intersecting identities that locate women in the social matrix (Collins, 2000). Failure to do so makes women and children more vulnerable. For instance, Lanctôt and Turcotte (2018) found that justice involved women may seek to distance themselves from deviant labels by pursuing normative mothering ideals that present them as "good moms." This leads to role strain and isolation as women with parenting struggles are reluctant to seek support for fear of being judged as a bad mother. Rather than reinforce cultural prescriptions of a "one size fits all" model of motherhood, a restorative justice approach encourages mothers to capitalize on their strengths and implement strategies that can make their children, families and communities whole. This is necessary if prisons are to become sites of positive transformation for incarcerated women rather than contribute to parental isolation and family dysfunction. Though women are influenced by conventional maternity, mothers demonstrate through their narratives that there are different ways to approach motherhood from prison. Yet having the will and resolve to mother their children is not enough. The current study affirms claims by Burke (1991) and Stets & Tsushima (2001) that role support is critical. Thus, if mothers are to be successful in managing their maternal roles and relationships with their children, they will likely need caregiver as well as institutional support to do so.

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